rendezvous. He had brought with him his relative Sultan Jan Barakzai, his father-in-law, the Ghilzai chief Mohammad Shah Khan, and a third chief whom the British did not recognise but who was in fact Aminullah Khan's younger brother, who had come to bear witness to Macnaghten's act of treachery.

The meeting started courteously enough. The Envoy presented Akbar with a valuable horse that he had previously complimented, and the young rebel leader politely thanked Macnaghten for double-barrelled pistols which the Envoy had sent to him along with his carriage and a pair of horses the day before. The party dismounted, and horse blankets were spread on a small hillock which the Afghans pointed out as being free from snow and whose position partially concealed them from the cantonment. The Envoy then sat down beside Akbar Khan, with Trevor and Mackenzie next to him. Lawrence stood behind Macnaghten until, pressed by Akbar, he knelt on one knee. Lawrence then pointed out the growing number of Afghans converging on the spot, saying that, if the subject of the conference was of a secret nature, the other men had better withdraw. Macnaghten repeated this to Akbar, who replied, 'They are all in the secret.' 'Hardly had he so said,' Lawrence wrote later, 'when I found my Arms locked, my pistols and sword wrenched from my belt and myself forcibly raised from the ground and pulled along. Mahomed Shah Khan Ghilzai who held me called out, "Come along if you value your life!" I turned and saw the Envoy lying, his head where his heels had been and his hands locked in Akbar's, consternation and horror depicted on his countenance.'[120]

As Lawrence was being dragged away, according to Mirza 'Ata:

> The Sardar [Akbar] shouted at Macnaghten, 'You are the Minister of a great King, the head of a glorious army, all foreign dignitaries pay tribute to your knowledge and accomplishments. But I must beg to differ, and consider you a fool, one whose word cannot be relied on, who reveals his inner treachery by what he writes! You have not been able to get the better of us in battle and now you seek to destroy us by deceit. You faithless, cheating trickster! So quick to betray our agreement! Do you think I would trust you rather than my fellow citizens of Kabul? Do you think it would be so easy to get us to mutually destroy each other for your convenience? Do you realise what a ridiculous figure you cut? Shame on you: you are a laughing stock! My intention was to have you honourably accompanied out of Kabul back to India; but your scheme was to have me assassinated. Your mind is darkened with black smoke and vain imaginings! Now you had better come with me into the city of Kabul!'